

Why Open Source Software is NOT Free

A common misconception among customers, who are not necessarily clued in to the open source philosophy, is about the 'free' attribute of open source. Here is how author explains to them what OSS is all about.



Image courtesy <http://northforker.com>

Many of my sales guys go into the field and face the following question put to them by customers, "We heard that open source is free. So why is your company charging us for it?"

At this point, I tell them a small story, which they can effectively use during their next sales call. Here is what I tell them.

Tom takes his girlfriend Jenny for a date to the beautiful seaside restaurant 'Jimbaran Bay' in Bali (Indonesia) and orders fresh lobsters—the costliest dish the restaurant offers. The sea breeze and the alcohol served in coconut shells makes them relax. The lobster arrives in exactly 30 minutes, as promised in the menu card. Jenny has never tasted a lobster before and is not sure how to eat it. Being the

experienced traveller that he is, Tom helps her out with the techniques of handling the lobster. Jenny loves the lobster and enjoys the entire experience of learning how to eat it.

The waiter brings the finger bowls for the couple to wash their hands, and the bill shortly afterwards. Tom picks up the bill, stares at it and exclaims, "What is this?"

"Sir, the bill for the lobster," the waiter replies.

"What do you mean by a bill for the lobster?" asks Tom.

"Sir, you and your friend just ate the lobster now. This is our bill for it," the waiter continues politely.

"But...I thought the lobster is freely available," Tom retorts, pointing towards the sea.

The waiter faints.

Once you narrate this incident to customers, the